

A DOSE OF PROTECTION
Jabuben Bharwad, 30, being vaccinated in Mahijada village, Ahmedabad

AMIT DAVE/REUTERS

depend not just on the variant but on its clinical treatment." The streamlining of Covid treatment helped prevent the disease from aggravating in many patients. "During the second wave, many patients would take steroids too early, or promising Covid drugs too late. Now, the timing of drugs has become universally known and has also helped keep the disease mild," says Dr Pandit.

Globally, there are new drugs now that have a greater chance of taming the virus (see *In the Pill Box*). Pfizer's antiviral drug Paxlovid, for example, cuts the risk of death and hospitalisation by almost 88 per cent. GSK and Vir Biotechnology's monoclonal antibody drug Sotrovimab reduces the same by 85 per cent and comes with a WHO recommendation. Both these are yet to be approved and made available in India. Experts say it is important India upgrade its clinical treatment guidelines to include global advances in Covid drugs. For example, the Merck pill by Ridgeback Biotherapeutics and Merck, approved by the FDA (US Food and Drug Administration) and in use in the UK, has been cleared in India but is not part of the Covid treatment guidelines due to safety concerns. Other treatments in the guidelines, such as Remdesivir and antibody cocktails, remain expensive. "If we have another surge such as the one in Delta, then affordable treatments and more efficacious drugs will really help reduce the load on hospitals," says Dr Farah Ingale, an internal medicine specialist with Fortis Hiranandani in Mumbai.

DESPITE 10 APPROVED VACCINES, JUST 3—COVISHIELD, COVAXIN AND SPUTNIK V—ARE IN INDIA'S ADULT VACCINATION PROGRAMME

PANDEMIC OF THE UNVACCINATED

On February 10, the WHO stated that the acute phase of the pandemic could end this year itself if 70 per cent of the world gets vaccinated. Currently, only 79 countries have given at least one dose to 75 per cent of their population. "We are connected in this pandemic," says Dr Budhiraja. "A strain in any other country will quickly reach India. So, it is not about vaccinating one country in isolation." In early 2021, Israel's vaccination programme showed that vaccines could reduce the number of new infections. Even when new strains emerged that could escape vaccine-acquired immunity, it was the unvaccinated who suffered the most. In the European Union, the Covid survival ratio this winter was 11 times higher than last winter when vaccinations had just begun. In the US, there were nearly four times as many positive cases for each death this year compared to last winter's peak, according to Bloomberg's Vaccine Tracker.